

Chapter 10: Surprising Findings

Brief Summary

This chapter gathers findings that surprised Vaillant or challenged common beliefs. It covers five topics: why the rich live longer than the poor, whether PTSD is caused by combat or pre-existing vulnerability, whether politics predicts mental health, whether religion improves health, and why maternal grandfathers might matter. The unifying theme is that longitudinal data can upset attractive explanations.

Key Study Findings

- The class-health relationship was partly explained by education. Inner City men who graduated from college lived about as long as Harvard men without graduate education, despite lower measured IQ and far less privilege.
- Education seemed to protect health through self-care, lower smoking, less obesity, more careful alcohol use, health literacy, planfulness, and hope for the future.
- Alcoholism confounded social-class health findings because it damages careers and health at the same time. Studies relying only on self-reported drinking may miss this.
- Combat exposure, not pre-existing personality disorder, predicted posttraumatic stress symptoms among the Study's World War II veterans.
- Neuroticism predicted other later psychological problems but did not predict PTSD symptoms. This distinction was only possible because the men had been studied before the war.
- Among men with high combat exposure, mature defenses predicted fewer posttraumatic symptoms and better survival.
- Politics did not predict the moral or developmental outcomes Vaillant expected. Liberals and conservatives had similar Decathlon scores, marriage stability, mental health, altruism, aging, and child relationships.
- Political orientation was surprisingly stable and linked to college personality traits: practical/pragmatic traits predicted conservatism, while introspective, creative, ideational, cultural, and sensitive traits predicted liberalism.
- Religious involvement did not improve mortality in the College cohort after health behaviors were considered, but it did offer comfort and possibly survival benefit among the most distressed men.
- The strangest finding concerned maternal grandfathers: their longevity, more than the other ancestors', was associated with lower anxiety, fewer psychiatric visits, and better psychological stability in grandsons. Vaillant treats this as provocative but preliminary.

Interesting Stories And Examples

- Bert Hoover and Charlie Weil embody the conservative and liberal poles. Their stories are colorful, but the data refuse Vaillant's personal prejudice that one political side would be more loving or healthier.
- The World War II combat analysis is a story of method: because the men had prewar psychological records and postwar debriefings, the Study could separate combat exposure from pre-existing vulnerability.
- The maternal-grandfather result reads like a scientific mystery. Vaillant speculates about possible X-linked inheritance but emphasizes that replication is needed.

Why It Matters

This chapter is a strong reminder that good evidence often irritates our favorite beliefs. It is useful for exams because it shows correlation, confounding, prospective design, and causal caution in action.